Cliff Notes: Effective Homelessness Advocacy Messaging Toolkit

Invisible People | 2025 | 37 pages | Founded by Mark Horvath

Your goal isn't to memorize this report. It's to understand its message well enough to explain it, discuss its findings, and apply its recommendations to conversations about homelessness in Chico.

> **THE CENTRAL MESSAGE:** People can support the same housing solution for entirely different reasons. Effective advocacy starts by understanding what matters to the person you're talking to ... and explaining how housing solutions address those concerns.

The toolkit is not primarily a study of how to end homelessness. It is a study of **how to communicate about ending homelessness so that more people support effective solutions.**

1. The five most important things to remember

- **Homelessness is also a communication challenge.** People disagree not only about solutions, but also about what causes homelessness. The words we use can either build bridges or reinforce divisions.
- **There is more common ground than we assume.** Political affiliation, income, and where someone lives do not fully predict their willingness to support housing solutions.
- **Two messaging approaches are essential.** Altruistic messaging appeals to compassion and community well-being. Self-benefit messaging appeals to safety, financial security, and individual interests.
- **Meet people where they are.** You don't have to change someone's values before they can support housing. Start with their existing concerns and show how housing addresses them.
- **Lead with solutions, not just criticism.** The toolkit argues that housing with supportive services is a better response to homelessness than punishment, displacement, or criminalization.

2. Understand the two messaging approaches

Altruistic messaging: Appeals to compassion, fairness, dignity, and shared responsibility. *Example:* "Everyone in our community deserves a safe place to call home."

Self-benefit messaging: Appeals to personal safety, economic interests, stability, and practical outcomes. *Example:* "Investing in housing can reduce the long-term costs of emergency services and improve neighborhood stability."

Neither approach is inherently better. The toolkit recommends using both, depending on the audience.

A powerful combination: "Everyone deserves a safe place to live ... and when we provide stable housing, our entire community becomes healthier, safer, and more financially secure." This is *hybrid messaging*.

3. The research findings worth remembering

The toolkit draws on a 2024 survey of 1,000 respondents and examines how different groups react to different messages.

Figure	What it means
52.4%	Of lower-income respondents showed positive engagement with both altruistic and self-benefit messaging.
43.4% / 39.1%	Altruistic action proportion among Democratic-leaning and Republican-leaning respondents, respectively.
7.2%	Variance in self-benefit messaging responses explained by income alone.
4%	Variance in altruistic response patterns explained by political affiliation alone.

Source: Toolkit pages 6–8 and 18. These percentages describe different research measures and should not be directly compared.

What these numbers mean: It's a mistake to assume someone will reject housing solutions simply because they're conservative, wealthy, suburban, or unfamiliar with homelessness. The way a solution is presented can matter considerably.

Three groups the toolkit examines:

Audience	What tends to resonate	How to begin
Urban, lower-income	Fairness, neighbors helping neighbors, stability	"We need to take care of each other."
Urban, middle-income	Strong communities, public health, thriving neighborhoods	"A healthier city benefits everyone."
Suburban, middle-income	Safety, property values, financial responsibility	"Let's invest in lasting solutions instead of repeatedly paying for emergencies."

These are clusters, not rigid categories. Age, income, politics, and geography alone should not predict someone's views.

4. What it says about criminalization

The toolkit argues that criminalizing homelessness does not address underlying causes. It may move people out of sight temporarily, but it does not create stable housing.

What someone says	What you need to communicate
"They need consequences to get off the streets."	Punishment doesn't make housing more affordable or available.
"They choose to be homeless."	Shelter rules, safety concerns, pets, family separation, and other barriers can make available shelter unsuitable.
"Arresting people is compassionate."	Stable housing and appropriate services provide a better foundation for recovery than jail.
"Homeless camps make neighborhoods unsafe."	Housing provides an alternative to living in public spaces. Displacement alone doesn't resolve the problem.
"Housing formerly homeless people will hurt neighborhoods."	Supportive housing includes services and case management to help residents succeed and address concerns.

What someone says	What you need to communicate
“We need tougher ordinances.”	Enforcement consumes public resources and can create additional barriers to housing.

Source: Toolkit pages 29–33. **Essential distinction:** addressing homelessness versus addressing its visibility. A city can remove an encampment without reducing the number of people experiencing homelessness.

5. Six motivations that can bring people together

- **Community support:** We all benefit when neighbors have stable homes.
- **Individual security:** Stable housing contributes to safer neighborhoods.
- **Personal gain:** Housing solutions can improve residents’ everyday quality of life.
- **Public safety:** Preventing crises is better than responding after they occur.
- **Social responsibility:** Everyone deserves dignity and a safe place to live.
- **Economic benefit:** Housing investments can reduce other public costs and support employment.

You don’t need all six in one conversation. Choose the one or two that matter to your audience.

6. How this applies to Chico

Person A: “We can’t afford another program.” Rather than arguing about whether they care about homeless people, ask whether the city has compared the ongoing costs of policing, temporary shelter, emergency services, and displacement against investments in permanent housing.

Person B: “I’m concerned about downtown businesses.” Acknowledge the concern, then explain that providing places for people to live offers a more durable way to reduce reliance on public spaces than continually moving people around.

Person C: “People should have to help themselves.” Agree that independence and personal responsibility matter, while explaining that housing stability can make employment, healthcare, and recovery more achievable.

You’re not abandoning your principles. You’re finding a shared starting point.

7. What to be careful about

- **Survey responses are not changed behavior.** Message preference does not prove someone will change how they vote.
- **This is not Chico-specific research.** Local costs, budgets, shelter conditions, and housing outcomes need independent evidence.
- **Some precise claims need verification.** For instance, page 31 makes a comparison of effectiveness and cost for housing with services versus criminalization. Check the underlying study before citing the ratio publicly.

Broad descriptions of demographics should not become stereotypes. The report emphasizes that people are more complicated than labels.

8. Your 60-second explanation of the toolkit

> "I've been studying a 2025 messaging toolkit from Invisible People, founded by Mark Horvath. It's based on research into how different audiences respond to conversations about homelessness.
>
> One of the most interesting findings is that we have more common ground than we think. People may disagree politically or have different reasons for caring about homelessness, but they can still support the same solutions.
>
> Some people are motivated by compassion and human dignity. Others care about public safety, financial responsibility, or neighborhood stability.
>
> The research suggests we don't have to convince everyone to think alike. We have to learn how to communicate with people based on the values we already share.
>
> And that's what interests me most ... finding ways to bring our community together around actual solutions instead of continuing to divide ourselves over the problem."

9. Questions you should be ready to answer

What is the toolkit's main purpose? To help advocates communicate about housing solutions more effectively with different audiences, using research on what motivates them.

What is the difference between altruistic and self-benefit messaging? Altruistic messaging focuses on helping others and strengthening the community. Self-benefit messaging focuses on safety, security, financial savings, and other personal advantages.

Does political affiliation determine whether someone supports housing? No. Party affiliation alone was a relatively weak predictor of messaging response. Message framing and other audience characteristics matter.

Is the toolkit saying we should manipulate people? No. It recommends communicating truthful benefits through the concerns and values that an audience already understands.

What's the toolkit's position on criminalization? It argues criminalization fails to resolve root causes and can create new barriers, favoring housing with supportive services instead.

What is one useful lesson for Chico? Discuss housing as a matter of dignity, public safety, economic responsibility, and community improvement at the same time.

10. What to read first in the original report

Priority	Pages	Why
Essential	2, 4	Understand purpose and central argument
Essential	6–8	Understand the most important research findings
Essential	10, 14–15	Learn both messaging approaches
Essential	30–34	Prepare for criminalization discussions
Helpful	17–18	How perceptions affect policy support

Priority	Pages	Why
Helpful	19–24	Understand the three audience clusters
Reference	25–28	Ready-made language for future conversations
Later	35–36	Methodology and contributors

Additional connection: Barbara Poppe and Iain de Jong are acknowledged on page 36 for feedback on the research. That does not mean they authored or endorsed every finding.

The one thought to take into a conversation

> **We don’t have to agree on why we care before we can agree on what needs to be done.**

Some want to reduce suffering. Others want safer neighborhoods. Others want more effective spending. Those motivations can all lead toward housing solutions ... and the opportunity to replace “us versus them” with what **we** can accomplish together.

Suggested first reading: pages 2, 6–8, 14, and 30–34. It is fine to say: “That’s a part of the research I’m still learning about.”

Based on Invisible People’s Effective Homelessness Advocacy Messaging Toolkit (2025). This guide is a summary, not an independent verification of its claims.